

Security issues

Since JavaScript is a full-featured language run in a browser, there's potential for things to go wrong. A malicious website could send a script to the browser that steals its cookies, or tampers with a user's account. Not knowing any better, the browser will run the script. However, disabling JavaScript is not the solution, as that will prevent browsers from accessing most of the modern web, including websites such as Google or Facebook.

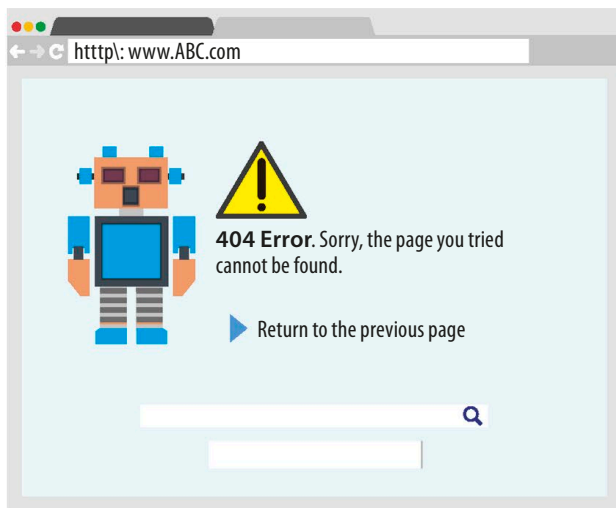
▷ Cross-site scripting

Cross-site scripting (XSS) exploits vulnerabilities in JavaScript to manipulate legitimate websites and make them send out bad scripts.



Compatibility problems

The web is built on the assumption that browsers can run JavaScript. This wasn't always the case. At first, each browser implemented their JavaScript engine a little bit differently, which led to many problems and broken websites. These days, everyone is more or less up-to-date. Programming languages are constantly changing, however, and if a website uses the most cutting-edge features of JavaScript, its code may not work for all visitors.



△ Old browsers

Since web technologies are constantly evolving, it's important to keep browsers up-to-date and to install the latest security patches. This will maximize both compatibility and security.

JavaScript plug-ins

Plug-ins are an extension of JavaScript. They are available for various things, such as making animations, drawing charts, and creating interactive maps. At a technical level, a plug-in is a file of JavaScript code that can be downloaded, added to other code files, and linked to a HTML page. JavaScript plug-ins can be written by anybody. It's important to check that you're downloading plug-ins from a legitimate source in order to prevent security breaches.



△ The JS toolbox

Think of plug-ins as extra tools in a toolbox. It doesn't make sense to include specialized tools in basic or default packages. That would needlessly make the toolbox bulky.